

LIWELILE IMPUMELELO COMMUNITY CENTRE

JAPAN PARTNERSHIP – STUDIO PROFILES

Document Reference: LICC/INT/JAPAN-PROFILES-001

Version: 1.0

Date: 19 March 2026

Prepared by: International Partnerships Coordinator

Status: Active Outreach Document

SECTION A: PROFILE INDEX

Priority	Studio/Organisation	Focus	Partnership Angle	Page
1	Arc & Beyond (Sony Group) / TAIDO Project	Animation skills transfer, co-production	Direct match – Sony-backed initiative actively seeking African partners	2
2	AnimaxFYB Studios (Ghana)	Animation production (African partner)	Peer learning – African studio already partnered with Japan	4
3	Pambili Media (South Africa)	Film/Content production	Local experience – already co-producing with Toei	5
4	N LITE / Afro-Anime (AFRIME)	"Afro-anime" production	Japanese studio dedicated to African stories	6
5	Polygon Pictures	3DCG animation	Expressed interest in South	8

Priority	Studio/Organisation	Focus	Partnership Angle	Page
			African partnership (2018)	
6	Toei Animation	Major studio (Dragon Ball, One Piece)	Largest Japanese studio; already partnering with SA	9
7	Wit Studio	Premium animation (Spy x Family, Attack on Titan)	Demonstrated openness to international co-productions	10
8	Production I.G	Prestige animation (Ghost in the Shell, Haikyuu!!)	Strong artistic credibility; potential for cultural exchange	11
9	AfroTokyo	Concept art, storyboarding	"Japanese Art, Brewed in an African Pot" – perfect brand alignment	12
10	MAPPA	Fast-growing studio (Jujutsu Kaisen, Chainsaw Man)	High commercial ceiling; international audience focus	13

SECTION B: STUDIO PROFILES

PROFILE #001: ARC & BEYOND (SONY GROUP) / TAIDO PROJECT

Field	Details
Priority Level	HIGHEST – DIRECT MATCH WITH ACTIVE AFRICA PROGRAMME
Organisation Name	Arc & Beyond
Parent	Established by Sony Group to address global social challenges
Sector	Animation development, skills transfer, co-production
Key Programme	TAIDO Project
Key Contact	Miyuki Kitabatake, Project Leader / Producer

Business Overview

Arc & Beyond was established by Sony Group specifically to address global social challenges through creative collaboration. Their TAIDO Project represents a strategic initiative to connect Japan's animation expertise with Africa's creative talent.

Project Leader Miyuki Kitabatake explains the rationale:

"Japan has fewer animators and our population is declining, but we still need to produce world-class animation. Africa has millions of talented people with unique stories. That is why we are here, to share technical knowledge, market access and production experience."

Key Philosophy:

Kitabatake emphasises that the aim is **not to replicate Japanese anime** but to ignite a wave of **original African content** built on technology and global collaboration.

"We don't want to make 'Japanese-style' animation. We want to support authentic African stories, created by African studios. We want to create something new for the world, authentic African stories delivered through strong innovation frameworks and global distribution networks."

TAIDO Project – Track Record

Partner	Project	Outcome
AnimaxFYB Studios (Ghana)	Capacity building, skills transfer	African studio gaining global production capacity
Comic Republic / CR Motion Plus (Nigeria)	"Trials of the Spear" animated feature	Spring 2026 global release; merging African storytelling with Japanese precision
Megumi Okawa (One Piece production manager)	Direction/production supervision	Direct involvement of senior Japanese talent

Partnership Potential for LICC

Area	Description
Skills Transfer	Mentorship and training through TAIDO Project structure
Co-Production Opportunities	Potential to develop South African stories with Japanese technical support
IP Ownership	African creators retain 100% intellectual property rights
Network Access	Introduction to JETRO, Japanese studios, and distribution channels
Comic Con Africa Connection	JETRO actively participates in Comic Con Africa

Relevance to LICC Vision

Factor	Assessment
"Tell South African stories"	✅ Direct alignment – TAIDO exists for this purpose
Skills transfer from Japan	✅ Core TAIDO mission
IP retention	✅ African creators keep ownership
Proven model	✅ Already working with Ghana and Nigeria
Sony backing	✅ Major corporate support

Next Steps

Action	Deadline	Responsible
Draft outreach email to Miyuki Kitabatake	31 March 2026	Chair + Intl Coordinator
Reference TAIDO Project's existing African partnerships (Ghana, Nigeria)	Outreach	
Express interest in exploring South African collaboration	Outreach	

PROFILE #002: ANIMAXFYB STUDIOS (GHANA)

Field	Details
Priority Level	HIGH – AFRICAN PEER WITH JAPANESE PARTNERSHIP EXPERIENCE

Field	Details
Organisation Name	AnimaxFYB Studios
Location	Accra, Ghana
Key Contact	Francis Y. Brown, Founder & Creative Director
Additional Contact	Ruth Ojougboh, Executive Producer

Business Overview

AnimaxFYB is one of Africa's leading 2D, 3D and VFX production companies. They are the lead African partner in the TAIDO Project with Arc & Beyond, positioning them at the forefront of Africa-Japan animation collaboration.

Francis Brown's Vision:

"Africa is already in the animation game, but we are not earning from it. In 2023, the global animation industry made over \$300 billion, and Africa contributed about \$15.5 billion, yet none of it stayed here because we were only consuming. Taido is here to change that."

Key Achievements:

- Won three awards at TAIDO African Animation Awards in Tokyo
- Developing capacity for African creators to compete globally
- Accessing advanced pipeline engineering and modern production systems through Japanese partnership

Partnership Potential for LICC

Area	Description
Peer Learning	Learn from an African studio already navigating Japanese partnership

Area	Description
Mentorship	Potential guidance from Ghanaian team on what works
Regional Collaboration	Possibility of West Africa-Southern Africa creative exchange
Network Introduction	Could facilitate introduction to Arc & Beyond team

Relevance to LICC

AnimaxFYB is essentially doing what LICC aspires to do – they are the Ghanaian model for what a South African animation partnership could look like. Their experience is invaluable.

Next Steps

Action	Deadline	Responsible
LinkedIn connection to Francis Brown	31 March 2026	Chair
Express interest in learning from their TAIDO experience	Outreach	

PROFILE #003: PAMBILI MEDIA (SOUTH AFRICA)

Field	Details
Priority Level	HIGH – DIRECT LOCAL EXPERIENCE WITH MAJOR JAPANESE STUDIO
Organisation Name	Pambili Media
Location	South Africa

Field	Details
Key Contact	Mandela Dube, Director
Notable Work	Directed Netflix thriller "Silverton Siege"

Business Overview

Pambili Media signed an agreement with **Toei Animation** – one of Japan's largest and most prestigious studios – to co-develop the feature film "**Yasuke: Butterfly's Path**" about the 16th-century African samurai.

Toei Vice President Yuji Kojima stated:

"This collaboration is not only a reinterpretation of history but also demonstrates Toei's commitment to continuous innovation."

The project is supported by South Africa's **Industrial Development Corporation** and is described as an "international epic connecting untold history and cross-continental culture".

Partnership Potential for LICC

Area	Description
Local Experience	Direct insights on negotiating with Japanese studios
Network Introduction	Potential introduction to Toei contacts
Peer Mentorship	Learn from Mandela Dube's experience with Japanese co-production
Industry Connections	Access to broader South African creative industry networks

Relevance to LICC

This is a South African company that has already done what LICC aspires to do – partner with a major Japanese studio. They are an invaluable local resource and potential mentor.

Next Steps

Action	Deadline	Responsible
Research Pambili Media contact details	31 March 2026	Intl Coordinator
Draft outreach email to Mandela Dube	7 April 2026	Chair
Request meeting to discuss their Toei partnership experience	Outreach	

PROFILE #004: N LITE / AFRO-ANIME (AFRIME)

Field	Details
Priority Level	HIGH – JAPANESE STUDIO DEDICATED TO AFRICAN STORIES
Organisation Name	N LITE
Location	Japan
Key Contact	Christiano Terry, Founder
Focus	"Afro-anime" (AFRIME) – African stories through Japanese animation

Business Overview

N LITE is a Japanese animation company with a mission to "expand the production of Black and Indigenous stories in collaboration with global creators, producing traditional 2D animation and expanding into series and films".

Current Projects:

Project	Description	Partners
Chiure: Child of the Sea	Feature film based on Mozambican folklore; follows Chiure, a young woman who protects her threatened coastal community after awakening a sleeping water god	South African studio LUCAN
MFINDA	Afro-anime feature	JuVee Productions (Viola Davis' company); Masao Maruyama (producer, Tokyo Godfathers); Gisaburō Sugii (director, Street Fighter II)
Ripper	Noir thriller	GONZO, Peter Ramsey (Spider-Verse director)
Hotaru	Sci-fi series	GONZO, Peter Ramsey

Notable Creative Team for MFINDA:

- Masao Maruyama – legendary producer (Tokyo Godfathers, In This Corner of the World)
- Gisaburō Sugii – director (Street Fighter II: The Animated Movie)
- Arthell Isom – co-director (D'Art Shtajio studio)
- Donald H. Hewitt – scriptwriter (English version of Spirited Away)

Partnership Potential for LICC

Area	Description
Direct Alignment	N LITE exists specifically to create Afro-anime – perfect match for LICC's vision

Area	Description
South African Connection	Already partnered with South African studio LUCAN for "Chiure"
Production Experience	Access to world-class Japanese creative talent
IP Ownership	Model suggests collaboration while respecting African stories

Relevance to LICC

N LITE is arguably the **most direct match** for LICC's Japan Track vision. They are a Japanese studio whose entire mission is to produce African stories through anime. Their existing partnership with a South African studio (LUCAN) proves they are already operational in this space.

Next Steps

Action	Deadline	Responsible
Research N LITE contact details	31 March 2026	Intl Coordinator
Research LUCAN (SA partner) for potential local introduction	31 March 2026	Intl Coordinator
Draft outreach email to Christiano Terry	7 April 2026	Chair
Reference "Chiure" and express interest in South African collaboration	Outreach	

PROFILE #005: POLYGON PICTURES

Field	Details
Priority Level	MEDIUM – HISTORIC INTEREST IN SA PARTNERSHIP
Organisation Name	Polygon Pictures
Founded	1983 (celebrated 35th anniversary in 2018)
Location	Tokyo, Japan
Specialisation	3DCG animation
Key Contact	Shuzo John Shiota, Spokesperson

Business Overview

Polygon Pictures is one of the oldest existing studios in the world focusing on CG animation production. They have animated shows for major international partners including Disney, Lucas Animation, Hasbro Studios, Amazon Studios, and Netflix .

Notable Works:

- Knights of Sidonia
- Blame!
- Godzilla animated feature trilogy (Netflix's first Original Anime)
- Star Wars: The Clone Wars (for Lucas Animation)
- Transformers Prime, Transformers Robots in Disguise (for Hasbro Studios)

International Presence:

Polygon has a subsidiary studio in Malaysia and partners with studios in Thailand, India, Taiwan, and China.

Partnership Potential for LICC

Shuzo John Shiota expressed explicit interest in South Africa (2018):

"The keys to success in our industry is very much dependent on how you can distinguish yourself creatively. A possible fusion of distinct creative cultures such as that of Japan and South Africa may be able to create an innovative style. The originality that the South

African design and sensibilities bring forth, may be able to complement our creative endeavours. The market potential is also an attraction."

Factor	Assessment
Historic Interest	✅ Explicitly expressed desire for SA partnership
International Model	✅ Proven experience with global co-productions
Timing	⚠️ Statement from 2018 – needs verification of current interest

Next Steps

Action	Deadline	Responsible
Research current Polygon Pictures leadership and contact	31 March 2026	Intl Coordinator
Reference their 2018 statement about SA potential in outreach	Outreach	
Verify continued interest in African collaboration	Outreach	

PROFILE #006: TOEI ANIMATION

Field	Details
Priority Level	MEDIUM-HIGH – JAPAN'S LARGEST STUDIO, ALREADY PARTNERING WITH SA
Organisation Name	Toei Animation

Field	Details
Founded	1948
Status	Publicly listed, Japan's largest anime studio by output
Notable Works	Dragon Ball, One Piece, Sailor Moon

Business Overview

Toei Animation is Japan's largest and most vertically integrated animation operation, with over 10,000 episodes produced across long-running franchises. Their international licensing operation is sophisticated, with direct relationships across North America, Europe, and Southeast Asia.

Key Facts:

- Vertically integrated – handles production, licensing, distribution
- Massive IP library with global recognition
- Already partnering with South Africa (Pambili Media on "Yasuke" film)

Partnership Potential for LICC

Area	Description
Existing SA Connection	Already working with Pambili Media – door is open
IP Library Access	Potential for licensing Japanese characters for LICC programmes/merchandise
Co-Production Possibilities	Toei is open to new IP co-productions and service work for international partners
Scale	Can provide significant resources if engaged

Note on Approach

For buyers, Toei's IP library is the primary draw, but flexibility on core franchise terms is limited. Where Toei does move is on **new IP co-productions and service work for international partners**.

Next Steps

Action	Deadline	Responsible
Connect with Pambili Media first (Profile #3) for introduction	April 2026	Chair
Research Toei's international co-production framework	Ongoing	Intl Coordinator

PROFILE #007: WIT STUDIO

Field	Details
Priority Level	MEDIUM – DEMONSTRATED INTERNATIONAL CO-PRODUCTION APPETITE
Organisation Name	Wit Studio
Founded	2012 (spun out of Production I.G)
Notable Works	Attack on Titan (seasons 1-3), Spy x Family (with CloverWorks), Ranking of Kings
International Work	Netflix original "Bubble" (with Gen Urobuchi)

Business Overview

Wit Studio built its reputation on Attack on Titan's first three seasons before MAPPA took over the finale. What's underappreciated about Wit is their **international co-production appetite**. They produced Spy x Family (alongside CloverWorks) and

demonstrated genuine openness to outside partnerships – including their collaboration on the Netflix original Bubble with Gen Urobuchi.

"For streaming platforms or international producers with compelling IP, Wit Studio is one of the more accessible conversations among premium-tier Japanese studios. They're building for global audiences – and that's not just marketing language. It shows in their story choices and visual direction choices that read across cultures."

Partnership Potential for LICC

Area	Description
Accessibility	One of the more approachable premium studios for international partners
Global Mindset	Proven interest in stories that work across cultures
Netflix Relationship	Experience with global streaming platforms

Next Steps

Action	Deadline	Responsible
Research Wit Studio international contact	Ongoing	Intl Coordinator
Consider approaching after initial JETRO introduction	Medium-term	

PROFILE #008: PRODUCTION I.G

Field	Details
Priority Level	MEDIUM – PRESTIGE STUDIO WITH ARTISTIC CREDIBILITY

Field	Details
Organisation Name	Production I. G
Notable Works	Ghost in the Shell, Haikyuu!!, Blood+, Psycho-Pass franchise

Business Overview

Production I.G carries serious artistic credibility and has a track record of producing intellectually sophisticated animation with international appeal. They are considered one of Japan's most respected studios.

Partnership Potential

While not as overtly focused on international co-productions as Wit Studio, Production I. G's artistic stature makes them an attractive long-term partner for any serious creative collaboration.

PROFILE #009: AFROTOKYO

Field	Details
Priority Level	MEDIUM-HIGH – PERFECT BRAND ALIGNMENT
Organisation Name	AfroTokyo
Tagline	"Japanese Art, Brewed in an African Pot"
Focus	Award-winning pre-production studio specialising in storyboarding and concept art
Location	Exhibiting at Comic Con Africa 2026 (Hall 7 – AA94)

Business Overview

AfroTokyo specialises in bringing African ideas to life through Japanese-styled visual storytelling. Their work spans edutainment, advertising, gaming, film, animation, manga, and comics industries.

Mission:

"Bringing African ideas to life, through Japanese styled visual storytelling."

Partnership Potential for LICC

Factor	Assessment
Brand Alignment	✅ Perfect – their tagline literally says it all
Comic Con Africa Presence	✅ Will be at Comic Con Africa 2026 – opportunity for in-person meeting
Complementary Skills	Storyboarding/concept art could integrate with LICC's creative training

Next Steps

Action	Deadline	Responsible
Research AfroTokyo contact details	31 March 2026	Intl Coordinator
Plan to attend Comic Con Africa 2026 and meet them in person	September 2026	Chair + team

PROFILE #010: MAPPA

Field	Details
Priority Level	MEDIUM – FASTEST-GROWING, HIGH COMMERCIAL CEILING
Organisation Name	MAPPA Co., Ltd.
Founded	2011 (by former Madhouse producer Masao Maruyama)

Field	Details
Notable Works	Jujutsu Kaisen, Attack on Titan: The Final Season, Chainsaw Man, Yuri on Ice

Business Overview

MAPPA is the story of the last five years – going from a promising upstart to the production house behind some of anime's biggest global hits. Jujutsu Kaisen alone generated over ¥150 billion in merchandise and licensing revenue.

Key Facts:

- Fastest-growing animation firm in Japan
- Specialises in non-action-based themes and compelling storylines
- Global audience reach proven through streaming platforms

Partnership Potential

MAPPA's growth trajectory carries real operational risk – the studio's rapid expansion has drawn scrutiny over animator working conditions, a structural issue across Japan's sector but particularly visible given their profile. For international buyers, the key questions are around production pipeline security and delivery timelines.

Note on Approach

The output quality justifies the conversation, but any approach should go in with eyes open about capacity constraints. MAPPA is likely best approached after establishing relationships through JETRO or other intermediaries.

SECTION C: CONTACT SUMMARY TABLE

Studio	Key Contact	Contact Method	Priority
Arc & Beyond	Miyuki Kitabatake	Email / LinkedIn	HIGHEST
AnimaxFYB	Francis Brown	LinkedIn	HIGH
Pambili Media	Mandela Dube	Research needed	HIGH

Studio	Key Contact	Contact Method	Priority
N LITE	Christiano Terry	Research needed	HIGH
Polygon Pictures	Shuzo John Shiota	Research current contact	MEDIUM
Toei Animation	(via Pambili)	Introduction needed	MEDIUM-HIGH
Wit Studio	International Dept	Via JETRO	MEDIUM
AfroTokyo	General contact	Comic Con Africa	MEDIUM-HIGH

SECTION D: NEXT STEPS SUMMARY

#	Action	Target	Deadline
1	Draft Arc & Beyond outreach email (Miyuki Kitabatake)	Arc & Beyond	31 March 2026
2	LinkedIn connection to Francis Brown (AnimaxFYB)	AnimaxFYB	31 March 2026
3	Research Pambili Media contact details	Pambili Media	31 March 2026
4	Research N LITE contact details	N LITE	31 March 2026
5	Research Comic Con Africa 2026 dates	AfroTokyo	31 March 2026

#	Action	Target	Deadline
6	Research Polygon Pictures current international contact	Polygon	15 April 2026

END OF JAPAN PARTNERSHIP – STUDIO PROFILES

This document provides:

- ☒ Comprehensive profiles of Japanese animation studios with Africa interest
- ☒ Direct matches: Arc & Beyond/TAIDO (Sony-backed), N LITE (Afro-anime), AfroTokyo (perfect brand alignment)
- ☒ Local connections: Pambili Media (SA with Toei partnership)
- ☒ African peer: AnimaxFYB (Ghana with TAIDO experience)
- ☒ Clear partnership angles and next steps for each